But a head massage was only a palliative; what Humayun needed urgently was a way of keeping his dignity, of tempering the gratitude that kept him on such precarious terms with his host. The age-old manner of repaying hospitality is with gifts, of course, and luckily for Humayun he had managed to hold on to a great diamond and 250 Badakhshani rubies. Abul Fazl makes sure to write that these gems ‘repaid more than four times over’ all that the Persians spent on Humayun over the course of his exile. It is Gulbadan, however, who tells the wonderful story of how the gems were almost lost, and with them, perhaps, Humayun’s chances of ever ruling his own kingdom again.

The story goes like this: Humayun kept his jewels in a small box that he would either wear around his neck or leave with Hamida. One day, when Humayun had left the case in her care, Hamida wrapped it in cloth, left it on their bed, and went to wash her hair. When she returned, the case was still there, but perceptibly lighter – someone had helped themselves to Humayun’s rubies.

Distraught and ashamed, Hamida went to her brother, Muazzam, and asked for his help. Muazzam revealed himself a talented sleuth. ‘One thing occurs to me!’ he said. ‘I, who am so closely connected with his Majesty, have not the means to buy even a poor pony’ – and yet two men from the company, Raushan Koka and Khwaja Ghazi, had just bought themselves a fine pair of horses. Off Muazzam went to the horse trader and found that, yes, indeed, the two men had promised payment in rubies. Next, Muazzam had a casual chat with one of Khwaja Ghazi’s attendants and discovered that the khwaja possessed no wallet nor chest, only a high cap, which he wore all day and clutched in his sleep all night.

The detective laid his trap. A boy known for eccentric behaviour, Muazzam began to play the fool around Khwaja Ghazi, teasing and making fun, until the older man learnt to deal with the annoyance by ignoring it. Thus, at an assembly, Muazzam was able to grab the hat from the khwaja’s head. He found the rubies in it, of course, and laid them before Hamida and Humayun.

So it was, writes Gulbadan, that Humayun was able to send an appropriate gift to Shah Tahmasp – the rubies were dazzling enough; the diamond may have been the Koh-i-noor – and ‘the two sovereigns again became of one